



YOU ARE **34 WEEKS AND 4 DAYS**

38 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

This 2-D ultrasound has captured the moment that the baby is sucking their thumb. Your baby is gradually learning to coordinate this complex activity with breathing movements even though they are surrounded not by air but by the amniotic fluid.

“Inside the uterus your baby is already practicing the suckling reflex, which will enable them to feed when they’re born.”

The suckling reflex is present earlier in pregnancy but it is known from assessing premature babies that it’s usually not until around this time that the baby is strong and coordinated enough to suckle with ease. Your baby regularly practices suckling and this, in combination with the rooting reflex, will enable your baby to feed.

After birth you will see the rooting reflex as your baby turns toward anything that strokes his cheek. The head will turn, and your baby will move his mouth in a series of gradually diminishing circles until the object is found. Once feeding is well established, at about four months, the rooting reflex disappears. From this point on, your baby has much more control over the process, able to turn and directly [latch on](#) to the nipple.

While in the uterus, there is no chance of your baby accidentally swallowing amniotic fluid into the lungs. The lungs are already filled with fluid and the high pressure of this, together with your baby’s larynx, keeps out amniotic fluid. After birth, babies have a series of reflexes designed to keep breathing and drinking separate. To help with feeding, babies always breathe through their nose.

ASK A DOCTOR

My mom has offered to stay with us after the birth. Is this a good idea? Some couples prefer to get to know their baby on their own, taking the first few days to settle in and get used to the idea of being new parents. It’s also good to try to do things your own way when it comes to caring for your newborn. Having said that, you’ll find an extra pair of hands invaluable.

It really depends on your relationship with your mom: if it’s good and you feel she’ll be supportive, then it’s more likely to help than hinder. However, gently establish some guidelines—namely that while you welcome her help, you’d like to do things your way and have space to bond with your baby. Encourage your mom toward helping around the house, rather than just with the baby, not least so that your partner doesn’t feel excluded at this important time.

ARE YOU READY FOR THE BABY?
